

DECODED

EXPLAINED

14th September 2026

A Rising Graph: Doping in Indian Sports

A rising graph

Doping is now a deep-rooted culture in Indian sports

At least 13 doping positives in the run-up to the recent Commonwealth Games and the upcoming Asian Games have again put India in an embarrassing spotlight. For a country that has been notoriously leading the global doping charts for three consecutive years, the spate of positive results across disciplines including athletics, weightlifting, wrestling, wushu and judo, has not only brought shame but has also robbed India of some berths in these prestigious events. The dope-tainted names have forced authorities to pull them out of the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games squad. More such names are expected to trickle out in the coming weeks. Lucrative cash incentives for Asian Games medalists are a major factor driving athletes and coaches to take shortcuts, risking their health and reputation, as well as the country's pride. While the spike in dope-positive results ahead of major multi-sport events is not new, the jump this time is a cause for concern. The matter getting raised during the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) workshops in Delhi, the Athletics Integrity Unit (AIU) downgrading India due to an extremely high risk of doping, and an international agency recently conducting surprise tests in Bhubaneswar and Bengaluru indicate the seriousness of the issue.

Even though National Sports Federations have been expressing concern, it cannot be said that they are strict to the core to curb the menace. Despite being seriously understaffed, the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA), which shoulders the primary anti-doping responsibility in India, has significantly increased the number of tests and raids based on intelligence gathering. But it needs to do more in a vast and populous country to discourage doping. Besides, NADA needs to get out of the government's control to function truly independently in order to enhance its effectiveness. Proper implementation of the National Anti-Doping (Amendment) Act, 2025, to give more powers to NADA and its allied bodies, is another requirement. With dope testing becoming costlier and NADA needing more staff, the government can bolster the fight against doping by increasing the overall budget allocation, which was reduced in the current budget. The other challenge is to cut the supply line, as India has become a hub for the trade in banned substances sourced from different countries. An Indian serving a jail term in Kenya for illegally importing performance-enhancing drugs stands as proof of this. As India prepares for the 2030 Commonwealth Games and hopes to host the Olympics in the future, it needs to act resolutely to weed out a deep-rooted doping culture in Indian sports.

Concept

Doping refers to the use of prohibited substances or methods by athletes to enhance performance unfairly.

Causes (DSS Framework)

1. Demand Side

- a. **Incentive-reward asymmetry:** Out-of-turn government jobs, cash awards, and reservation quotas for medal winners create a results-at-any-cost incentive structure, disproportionate to the risk of sanction.
- b. **Socio-familial pressure:** Sport's low legitimacy as a career choice in India intensifies pressure from coaches/family for quick success, shrinking the athlete's time horizon and encouraging shortcuts.

2. Supply Side

- a. **Unregulated pharmaceutical access:** Over-the-counter availability of anabolic-androgenic steroids (AAS) at gyms/pharmacies without prescription control bypasses drug-scheduling safeguards.
- b. **Weak testing and monitoring mechanisms:** Sparse out-of-competition testing (OOCT) and near-absent doping control at district/state-level meets lower the probability of detection, undermining deterrence (a core assumption of anti-doping enforcement).

3. Systemic

- a. **Awareness deficit:** Athletes consuming supplements/medicines via local trainers without knowledge of the WADA Prohibited List or Therapeutic Use Exemption (TUE) norms leads to inadvertent doping, especially relevant given the strict liability principle (athletes are responsible for what's found in their system regardless of intent).
- b. **Infrastructure deficit:** Poor training facilities and lack of sports science support (nutrition, physiotherapy, biomechanics) push athletes toward pharmacological shortcuts to compensate for scientific gaps.
- c. **Governance failure:** Nepotism, opaque selection processes, and financial irregularities in sports federations erode athlete trust and welfare, indirectly enabling anti-doping rule violations (ADRVs) through systemic neglect.

Basics

National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA)

NADA is India's autonomous statutory body, established in 2005, responsible for promoting and monitoring anti-doping in sports. (National Anti-Doping Act, 2025)

Functions: NADA is responsible for planning, implementing, and coordinating India's anti-doping activities. It adheres to the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) code and regulations.

World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA)

WADA, founded in 1999 by the International Olympic Committee (IOC), is the global independent authority tasked with promoting and coordinating the fight against doping in sports.

Governance Model: Operates on a unique principle of equal partnership and funding between the global Sport Movement and Governments.

Pakistan's Westward Turn : Strategic Depth or Overstretch

Pakistan's westward turn — strategic depth or overstretch

The defence cooperation agreement signed by Pakistan and Kuwait on August 27, 2026, is the latest manifestation of Pakistan's rapidly expanding strategic footprint in West Asia. The agreement assumes greater significance when viewed alongside Pakistan's membership of the Saudi Arabia-Türkiye-Pakistan defence arrangement and its recent role as an intermediary between Iran and the United States.

Enduring links

Pakistan's West Asian orientation has deep historical roots. From its inception, it attempted to combine its South Asian geopolitical identity with that of a major Muslim power. During the Cold War, Pakistan, Iran and Türkiye were linked through the Central Treaty Organization (CENTO) and subsequently through the Regional Cooperation for Development.

The decisive turn towards the Arab world came after Pakistan's defeat and dismemberment in 1971. It sought to compensate for its diminished position in South Asia by emphasising its Islamic identity, symbolised by the Islamic summit held in Lahore in 1974. Pakistan simultaneously developed extensive military relationships with Saudi Arabia and the Gulf monarchies.

What is new, therefore, is not Pakistan's involvement in West Asia but its increasing institutionalisation. The Makkah Agreement of August 7 stipulated that an armed attack against one member would be regarded as an attack against all. The three countries moved quickly to give the arrangement institutional substance. At the August 31 meeting in Istanbul, their Foreign and Defence Ministers and military chiefs decided to establish a permanent secretariat in Saudi Arabia, with a Pakistani serving as its first Secretary-General for three years. They also agreed to strengthen military interoperability and pursue defence-industrial cooperation, including



Mohammed Ayooob

University Distinguished Professor Emeritus of International Relations, Michigan State University, and the author of 'From Regional Security to Global IR' (2024)

Pakistan's expanding West Asian role brings influence and opportunity, but also strategic risks

joint technology development and production.

But the new arrangement is already confronting Pakistan with the contradictions inherent in its expanding West Asian role. Renewed Houthi missile and drone attacks against Saudi Arabia created the first serious test of the Makkah pact. The Houthis' recent capture of Mocha port and Perim island have further added to their capability to choke off Saudi shipping through the Bab al-Mandab. With the Strait of Hormuz effectively closed by Iran, a frustrated Saudi Arabia may re-launch a full-fledged war against the Houthis. This could create a major dilemma for Pakistan especially if Riyadh decides to invoke the collective-defence provision of the Makkah agreement.

Pakistan wants to be Saudi Arabia's security partner, Türkiye's strategic ally, Iran's friend and interlocutor, Washington's useful intermediary, and an increasingly important security provider to the Gulf monarchies. These roles are compatible when regional tensions are manageable. They become irreconcilable when they are not.

What it means for India

For India, Pakistan's westward turn presents both a challenge and a potential relief. A Pakistan embedded in a network of West Asian security relationships may acquire defence in depth. Saudi financial resources, Turkish defence technology and Pakistan's expanding relationships with Gulf militaries can theoretically increase Islamabad's resilience in a confrontation with India. Türkiye is already Pakistan's most vocal major supporter on Kashmir. Pakistan's nuclear status also enhances its strategic value to Arab states concerned about an increasingly unstable regional order because of nuclear-armed Israel's aggressive policies.

But strategic depth can easily become strategic overstretch. Pakistan's security establishment has

historically concentrated overwhelmingly on India. A Pakistan increasingly required to devote diplomatic, military and intelligence resources to Iran, Saudi Arabia, the Gulf, Yemen and the Red Sea may have fewer resources to concentrate on India.

The current Saudi-Houthi confrontation and the distinct possibility of it spawning a war clearly demonstrate the danger of Pakistan's strategic overstretch. The deeper Pakistan becomes embedded in West Asian security arrangements, the harder it will become to remain aloof from the region's conflicts. If the Houthi-Saudi confrontation escalates, Islamabad may eventually have to choose between honouring the credibility of its collective-defence commitments and maintaining its carefully cultivated relationship with Tehran, the Houthis' principal ally.

India should therefore resist interpreting Pakistan's growing West Asian role in purely negative terms. Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates and the other Gulf states have major economic and strategic relationships with India that they are unlikely to sacrifice for Pakistan.

New Delhi should continue deepening these relationships as a counter to Pakistan's expanding footprint in West Asia.

The consolidation of Pakistan's West Asian relationships undoubtedly provides it with greater strategic depth *vis-à-vis* India. But those very relationships expose it to some of the world's most combustible rivalries. For India, therefore, Pakistan's westward turn contains a paradox. A Pakistan more deeply embedded in a West Asian security structure may in theory look strategically stronger. But a Pakistan entangled in mutually contradictory West Asian commitments will soon discover that it could be indefinitely stuck in a quagmire of its own choosing. It is far more difficult to get off the tiger than to get on it.

Concept

- The August 27, 2026 Pakistan-Kuwait defence cooperation agreement is the latest sign of Pakistan's expanding strategic footprint in West Asia, significant alongside its Saudi-Türkiye-Pakistan defence arrangement and its role as an Iran-US intermediary.
- Pakistan's West Asian orientation isn't new, since its founding it has tried to combine a South Asian identity with a Muslim-world identity, formalized via CENTO during the Cold War and later the Regional Cooperation for Development.
- Central Treaty Organization (CENTO)
 - CENTO, originally called the Middle East Treaty Organization, was a mutual security organisation from 1955 to 1979.
 - Its founding members were Turkey, Iran, Pakistan, the United Kingdom, and initially Iraq, with headquarters in Baghdad.
 - The organisation aimed to counter Soviet expansion into the Middle East's vital oil-producing regions.
 - After Iraq's withdrawal in 1959, CENTO's headquarters moved to Ankara, and the United States became an associate member, and the name of the organisation was changed to CENTO
 - CENTO was dissolved in 1979 following the Iranian Revolution and Iran's subsequent withdrawal.

Argument of Strategic Overstretch

- Pakistan's security establishment has historically focused almost entirely on India; now it must spread resources across Iran, Saudi Arabia, the Gulf, Yemen, and the Red Sea, potentially leaving less capacity to focus on India.

At BRICS, India Must Bank on the NDB

At BRICS, India must bank on the NDB

India should use BRICS to maximise the grouping's potential without strengthening Beijing, with the New Development Bank offering a practical avenue for cooperation: strengthening the NDB through greater capital, membership and local-currency lending can make BRICS more relevant

ECONOMIC NOTES

Amit Kumar
Anushka Saxena

In September 12, leaders of the BRICS grouping gathered at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi, with India holding the chair and, by extension, the pen. When BRICS came together in 2011, its five members contributed 20% of global GDP, but held just 1% of the voting share at the International Monetary Fund (IMF).

Today, the expanded grouping accounts for nearly 40% of global GDP and 55% of the world's population, but the voting share has barely expanded.

Beyond that grievance, BRICS does not, and will never, possess a coherent geopolitical identity. Russia, China and Iran would like it to be anti-West, while India, Brazil and South Africa insist it is better understood as non-West. Given these divergences and the importance of the India-US ties, Delhi cannot lend itself to the Beijing-Moscow de-dollarisation crusade. Not only would that add fuel to the fire at a time when ties with Washington are already strained, but it would also be an unsustainable proposition to advocate in the medium term.

India's approach to BRICS has to conform to the broader constraints and contradictions that its membership poses – maximising the grouping's potential without strengthening Beijing's overall strategic position. Within these constraints, there are still possibilities to keep the grouping relevant.

Making the NDB count

One area where BRICS can contribute the most meaningfully to the global financial order, without overtly threatening or challenging American predominance, is by expanding the efficiency and membership of the New Development Bank (NDB). Established by the BRICS countries in 2015 to "mobilise resources for infrastructure and sustainable development projects in BRICS and other emerging markets and developing countries", the bank remains one of the grouping's most tangible tools.

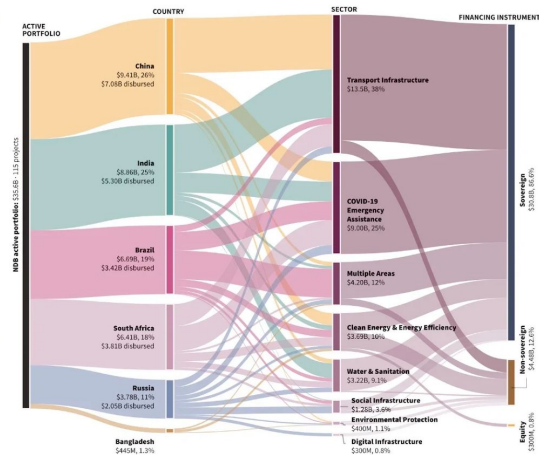
Yet, despite a decade in operation, the NDB has approved only 120 projects worth about \$43 billion, distributed mostly among its core members. Its like-for-like counterpart, the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB), established around the same time, has meanwhile gathered 111 approved members and committed about \$69 billion across 350 projects, backed by a AAA credit rating that the NDB cannot easily attain. Stagnant asset growth continues to restrict its lending capacity. This is coupled with an exceptionally slow disbursement rate: only about \$20 billion of approved loans had been disbursed, according to the bank's own count.

Breaking the asset bottleneck

One pathway to breaking this asset bottleneck would be for the five countries to increase their paid-up capital. However, severe domestic and geopolitical constraints mean that not all founders can match higher commitments – most notably, Russia, which is heavily sanctioned. Sanctions have also strained the bank's credit standing and dollar funding costs. What is ironic is that even as Moscow and Beijing champion de-dollarisation, including through the Bank, the NDB has extended no new credit to Russia since March 2022 to

Where the money flows

China and India together account for 53% of the New Development Bank's active portfolio, while transport infrastructure takes the largest share



This portfolio includes loan amounts repaid and projects cancelled. NDB has approved \$43.8 billion across 130 projects in total since 2015; the difference is 24 projects and about \$1.4 billion that have been fully repaid or cancelled. (minor country-by-sector flows are estimated and scaled to NDB's published totals)



The 18th BRICS Summit concluded on Sunday, in New Delhi. AP

protect its AAA/AA+ credit rating. And since the bank's rules mandate equal voting shares among the founders, any capital expansion is effectively held hostage by its financially weakest link. The NDB has also opened its doors to new members, allowing for a fresh infusion of capital, but the founders' collective voting share cannot fall below 5%.

Regardless of how the bottleneck is resolved, there is merit in repositioning the NDB within BRICS. So far, the bank has served Delhi well. It has secured commitments of nearly \$30 billion across 22 projects, including metro rail systems and the Delhi-Ghaziabad-Meerut RRTS corridor. It is not a small feat, but expanding the NDB's operations to be on par with other multilateral lenders would require extending such a bargain to many more emerging markets and developing

countries. It is also a noteworthy strength of the NDB that it has a marked preference for local-currency lending. This mechanism appeals to emerging economies, especially at a time when the volatility in foreign-exchange markets is sustained because of global wars, both military and economic. It is an alternative way to reduce reliance on the dollar without replacing it as a currency for trade invoicing. The bank's 2022-26 General Strategy commits to 30% of its lending and borrowing in member countries' local currencies, even as the bulk of its lending and borrowing remains in dollars. Whatever local currency lending does exist is skewed heavily in favour of the Renminbi – just a few days ago, the NDB priced a \$7 billion (\$1.04 billion) three-year Panda bond in the China

interbank bond market. In 2026, issuance of such bonds has gone up approximately 90% year-on-year, per Chinese data.

Pushing the rupee bond

It is time for India to push the long-delayed rupee bond over the line. First discussed in 2016, and subsequently slated for October 2023 and then for end-March 2026, the debut issuance was described by NDB President Dilma Rousseff in May as being at its "final stage", two months after the bank floated a rupee bond programme to mobilise around ₹25,000 crore over five years. Further, given the fact that the 2026 New Delhi Declaration did not feature a meaningful agreement on mobilising the NDB, India's focus in BRICS next year should be on simpler fixes to local-currency challenges.

Unlike the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, whose Summit recently concluded with bare-minimum outcomes, BRICS has tangible economic tools and a wider membership than ever before. In a world drifting towards subscription multilateralism, with Washington's pay-to-shape the rules Board of Peace as its latest specimen, these arrangements are the only way the grouping will truly set itself apart.

(Amit Kumar and Anushka Saxena are researchers at the Takshashila Institution. Views are personal to the authors and do not represent those of the Institution. Graphic Data Source: NDB; Investor Presentation June 2026 & Annual Report 2025; created by the authors)

THE GIST

BRICS' growing economic and demographic weight has not been matched by greater influence at institutions such as the IMF, while divisions among members prevent it from developing a coherent geopolitical identity

The NDB remains one of BRICS' most tangible economic instruments, but its lending and disbursement have lagged behind the AIIB, with weak asset growth and constraints arising from sanctions on Russia and the bank's voting structure

India should push for the long-delayed rupee bond and focus on practical local-currency measures, while using the NDB to extend development finance to more emerging markets and developing countries

Concept

- The Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) is a multilateral development bank that provides financing for infrastructure projects in Asia.
- AIIB is the first major multilateral development bank where principal contributors are the borrowing members.
- The main objective was to provide developing countries with an alternative to Western lending institutions, like the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund.
- Headquarters: Beijing, China.
- Objective: To finance infrastructure projects in the Asia Pacific region.
- Member countries: 109 Countries
- India is a founding member.
- Membership in AIIB shall be open to members of the World Bank or the Asian Development Bank.
- It has a total authorised capital of USD\$100 billion.
- China is the largest contributor to the Bank, contributing USD 50 billion, half of the initial subscribed capital.
- India is the second-largest shareholder, contributing USD 8.4 billion.
- China is the biggest shareholder (27% voting shares). India is the 2nd largest shareholder (8%) followed by Russia and Germany.
- India is by far the top recipient of AIIB loans, accounting for almost 20% of the bank's projects.

Regarding the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) consider the following statements:

- 1. AIIB has more than 80 member nations.**
- 2. India is the largest shareholder in AIIB.**
- 3. AIIB does not have members from outside Asia**

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

This question was previously asked in
**Official UPSC Civil Services Exam
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1. 1 only

2. 2 and 3 only

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4. 1, 2 and 3

A Blueprint to Create Productive Jobs — A Lesson from Tiruppur

A blueprint to create productive jobs, a lesson from Tiruppur



FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH

BY ASHOK GULATI AND
SULAKSHANA RAO

IN HIS Independence Day address from the Red Fort's ramparts, Prime Minister Narendra Modi placed "manufacturing power" as the first among the seven Saptadharma streams that are to take India towards a Viksit Bharat. He also said this effort would fully harness the potential of India's youth. The pertinent question is, which manufacturing sector can actually deliver jobs at the scale India needs?

Our research at ICRIER points to the textiles and apparel (T&A) sector. But first, why is creating jobs urgent? India's growth story will have little meaning if it fails to create jobs for the masses, and that too in the formal sector. India had 61.6 crore employed persons aged more than 15 years (2025), but agriculture still accounted for 43 per cent of employment, compared with 12.1 per cent in manufacturing (PLFS 2025). Even a 1 percentage point shift in employment from agriculture to manufacturing would involve moving a large number of workers. The NDA had promised to create 2 crore jobs every year, but reality is nowhere near that. The recent student agitations over paper leaks reflected an underlying frustration: Even after acquiring a "three Rs" education, respectable jobs in the formal sector remain scarce. Unemployment among those aged 15-29 was 9.9 per cent, rising to 13.6 per cent in urban areas, while 25 per cent were neither in employment nor in education or training (PLFS 2025). Female labour force participation was 40 per cent, compared with 79.1 per cent for men.

A large share of India's workforce remains in informal employment, without the stability and social protection of formal jobs. The PLFS usual-status measure includes people who worked for a long part of the year

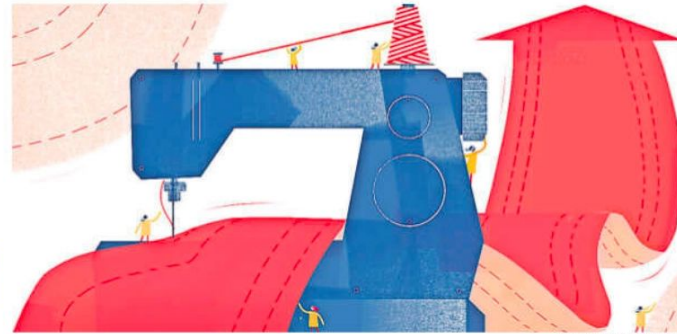


ILLUSTRATION: C R SAKSHUMAR

as well as those who undertook economic activity for at least 30 days during the year. Being counted as "employed" does not necessarily mean having a regular/formal job. For workers to build economic security and resilience, the shift must therefore be towards regular, formal employment with social-security benefits like Employees' Provident Fund (EPF) and Employees' State Insurance (ESI). This is where the apparel sector matters. It is labour-intensive, employs women in large numbers and can train workers in short periods, about 60 days for specific production roles.

India has set an ambitious target of \$100 billion in T&A exports by 2030 (from \$36 billion today). Of this, \$40 billion is for apparel exports specifically (from \$15.7 billion today). But our interactions with exporters suggest that these targets are not grounded in current realities. They are more likely to be achieved by 2035, not 2030.

One good thing is that India has recently closed the tariff gaps with competitors like Bangladesh and Vietnam in major markets like the EU and the UK. But market access alone does not ensure exports. Take the example of the India-Japan agreement (2011). India's apparel exports to Japan fell from \$229 million in 2013 to \$203 million in 2024.

The Tiruppur Exporters Association played an important role in building collective capabilities, while infrastructure such as the Netaji Apparel Park supported its expansion

We need the scale and capacity to tap the potential of free trade agreements. The solution is not more factories, but creating a competitive ecosystem around them.

Tiruppur, an organically grown knitwear cluster, is perhaps the most compelling example. Its knitwear exports rose from \$3.3 billion in 2020-21 to \$5.3 billion in 2024-25 (TEA, 2026). The cluster accounts for about 68 per cent of India's knitwear exports and supports the livelihoods of more than a million workers, around 70 per cent of them being women. Within roughly 20 km, yarn, knitting, dyeing, printing, stitching, finishing, packaging and dispatch are woven into one production ecosystem. Nearly 20,000 units operate across different stages, from knitting, dyeing and printing to garmenting and ancillary activities. This is the ecosystem effect where firms specialise,

workers specialise, and thousands of jobs are created around a common market.

So how did Tiruppur do it? Over decades, entrepreneurs, industry associations and government built the institutions and common infrastructure that enabled this ecosystem to grow. The Tiruppur Exporters Association, under the leadership of A Sakthivel, and the

South India Hosiery Manufacturers Association played an important role in building collective capabilities, while infrastructure such as the Netaji Apparel Park supported its expansion. The cluster's collective strength was evident in tackling the environmental crisis. After the Madras High Court's 2011 order on units failing to meet zero-liquid-discharge (ZLD) norms, the cluster invested more than Rs 850 crore in common effluent-treatment infrastructure. Tiruppur also shows what it takes to create the next 1 million jobs. The cluster depends heavily on migrant workers from Odisha, Jharkhand, Bihar and elsewhere, making worker housing and retention important challenges. The cluster plans to foray into man-made fibres, technical textiles and high-value sustainable manufacturing to expand both exports and employment.

But Tiruppur alone cannot help achieve the target of \$100 billion in T&A exports by 2030. India needs many more such clusters. Some policy steps in this direction were taken by the government in 2021 in the form of announcing seven PM MITRA parks. But till date, only one such park seems operational (the Warangal one). Others are still in the planning stages. Such a snail's pace in the execution of even good ideas does not inspire confidence that India can achieve its target of \$100 billion exports by 2030. That would also limit the speed at which jobs can be created.

Our humble submission is that the Prime Minister needs to give special attention to this sector if India is to create 20 million meaningful jobs every year. Chip-making, AI and other advanced technologies are important for India's future, but they are for the highly skilled workforce, while the majority of India's labour force is at the bottom end. The T&A sector offers higher employment intensity at relatively low cost. China, Bangladesh, and Vietnam have followed that path, and India needs to learn from them.

The real test of Viksit Bharat is whether it can create enough productive jobs. T&A offers a clear opportunity. But it needs the PM's focus to expedite its execution.

Gulati is distinguished professor and Rao is senior fellow at ICRIER. Views are personal

Concept

Tiruppur as the model

Tiruppur knitwear exports rose from \$3.3 billion (2020-21) to \$5.3 billion (2024-25), accounting for ~68% of India's knitwear exports and supporting over a million workers (70% women). Within a 20km radius, the entire production chain : yarn, knitting, dyeing, stitching, packaging, is integrated into one ecosystem, with ~20,000 units operating across specialized stages. This is the "ecosystem effect": firms specialize, workers specialize, and thousands of jobs cluster around a common market.

Terror's Changing Face, India's Counter-Terror Strategy

Terror's changing face, India's counter-terror strategy

The terror attack carried out by al-Qaeda on the Twin Towers in New York on September 11, 2001 was neither the first major terrorist attack in the world nor the first against the United States. But it fundamentally changed how terrorism would be fought in the decades that followed.

Over the past 25 years, the global security landscape, including that of India, has changed irreversibly. The forms of terrorism have evolved, the instruments used to perpetrate terror have changed, and so too have the strategies adopted by countries around the world to counter terrorism.

We no longer hear of large terror groups operating under ruthless terrorist leaders such as al-Qaeda founder Osama bin Laden or Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi, who led the Islamic State and called for the establishment of an Islamic Caliphate. Instead, terror groups have morphed into smaller, more autonomous entities. Lone-wolf attacks are becoming the norm, while new technologies such as drones, cyber capabilities, and even artificial intelligence are being used not only by terror groups but also by nations combating terrorism.

From an Indian standpoint, 9/11 certainly helped bring greater attention to India's concerns over cross-border terrorism, particularly in Kashmir. However, it was not until the 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks (November 2008) that the world truly stood in solidarity with India and acknowledged its fight against cross-border terrorism. Over the years, India's strategy towards terrorism has evolved – from a passive strategy of merely warning Pakistan but not punishing it, to a bold and active strategy that classifies any act of terrorism backed by support from across the border as an 'act of war'.

The starting years saw a passive response

Although cross-border terror commenced in Kashmir in early 1990s, the first major terror attack did not come from the Kashmir Valley. The assassination of former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi by the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam terror group of Sri Lanka on May 21, 1991 in Sriperumbudur, Tamil Nadu shook the nation.

With no clearly defined counter-terror strategy and a rapidly expanding terror network in Kashmir, India found itself stretched. The March 1993 Mumbai serial blasts, which killed over 250 people in 13 coordinated blasts across the city, and the synchronised blasts across Coimbatore city (Tamil Nadu) in February 1998 exposed the inadequacies of India's internal security mechanisms to detect and fight terror inside the country.

However, the direct role of Pakistan was first exposed with the hijack of Indian Airlines flight IC-814, on December 24, 1999. Under tremendous public pressure and with very few options, India agreed to release dreaded Pakistan-based terrorists such as Ahmed Omar Sheikh and



Rajeev Agarwal

Retired colonel, Senior Research Consultant at CRF, Delhi and the author of the book, 'Between Tehran and Tel Aviv: Gaza's Story of Unending War'

Masood Azhar in exchange for more than 160 civilian hostages. The attack on India's Parliament in New Delhi by the Pakistan-based Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM) terrorist group on December 13, 2001 outraged India and led to a large-scale military mobilisation under 'Operation Parakram'. With India and Pakistan having acquired nuclear weapons, the threat of escalation grew, prompting the international community to rush in to cool tempers. After almost two years of a tense standoff, the military disengagement took place without any direct punishment on Pakistan. The 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks – widely considered India's 9/11 moment – also did not lead to any military action against Pakistan.

There were other terror attacks too, such as the 2002 Akshardham Temple attack, the 2006 Varanasi serial bomb blasts, and the 2010 German Bakery blast in Pune. Delhi, too, was not left untouched by terror. Even before the Parliament attack, an Army garrison within the Red Fort was targeted on December 22, 2000 by Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) terrorists, resulting in the deaths of three soldiers. In October 2005, over 60 people were killed in serial blasts that rocked popular Delhi markets, including Sarojini Nagar and Paharganj. Again, in September 2008, months before the 26/11 Mumbai attacks, multiple blasts rocked commercial areas of Delhi, including Connaught Place, Greater Kailash, and Karol Bagh. On September 7, 2011, a briefcase bomb exploded outside the Delhi High Court, killing 15 people. The attack was claimed by Harkat-ul-Jihad Islami (HUJI), a terror group affiliated with al-Qaeda and largely based in Pakistan. In all these cases, and many others, India chose not to respond directly and decisively, even after conclusive proof of Pakistan's direct support for these attacks. How and when, then, did India change its strategy?

Taking the fight across the border

It was after a change of government at the Centre in May 2014, and its resolve not to let terror go unpunished, that India changed its strategy towards cross-border terrorism. The terror attack on September 18, 2016 by Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM) terrorists on an Army camp in Uri, Kashmir, led to the first cross-border surgical strikes (September 28-29). The strikes not only sent a strong message but also served as a clear statement of intent. Soon thereafter, following the terror attack on a Central Reserve Police Force convoy in Pulwama, Kashmir, on February 14, 2019, the Indian Air Force (IAF) launched strikes on a JeM terror camp in Balakot. This marked the first time that the IAF had crossed into Pakistani airspace to carry out a strike against a terror target.

However, it was the terror attack in Pahalgam on April 22, 2025 that outraged the nation like never before. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who was on a visit to Saudi Arabia, returned to India and soon after, the Indian armed forces

launched Operation Sindoor on May 6-7, hitting the heart of the Pakistan-based terror network. In a matter of 96 hours, the leaders and headquarters of the terror networks (LeT and JeM) were destroyed and Pakistani military assets were pulverised.

Where India stands on terror now

India has come a long way since the menace of cross-border terrorism took root in Kashmir in the early 1990s. From a passive and reactive policy, India has emerged as a leading voice in the global fight against terrorism. Soon after Operation Sindoor, India declared three clear intentions – first, that the era of restraint and patience is over, and Pakistan will have to pay a direct and heavy price for any terror attack in the future. Second, that any future act of cross-border terrorism emanating from Pakistan will be treated as an 'act of war'. Third, that Pakistani nuclear blackmail will no longer be a restraining factor.

India also unveiled 'PRAHAAR', its first comprehensive National Counter-Terrorism Policy and Strategy, on February 23, 2026. The policy provides a national counter-terrorism framework for preventing and responding to terrorist activities and radicalisation through coordinated "whole-of-government" and "whole-of-society" approaches.

Although the number of terror-related incidents in Kashmir has declined drastically, the possibility of a few terrorists infiltrating across the Line of Control (LoC) and evading intelligence and security agencies remains. The answer lies in a four-fold strategy. First, continue to hunt down and eliminate the remnants of the terror network in the country, particularly in Kashmir. Second, take pre-emptive military action against any potential terror threat building across the LoC, including at terrorist launch pads. With years of experience and a deeply embedded intelligence network, this is possible. Third, undertake an exhaustive de-radicalisation programme across the country that not only motivates young people to join the mainstream but also makes the prospect of joining or supporting a terror outfit unattractive and prohibitively costly. Fourth, take all necessary steps to cut off terror financing, in close coordination with friendly countries.

Twenty-five years after 9/11, the threat of terrorism across the globe has not been eliminated but has instead morphed into new forms. At the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Summit in Bishkek on September 1, Mr. Modi called out the double standards on terrorism and said, "We must send a strong message to countries that use terrorism as an instrument of policy and provide safe haven and support to terrorists that terrorism can never be a strategic asset for anyone." At the 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi, an exclusive paragraph on the Pahalgam terror attack was included in the Delhi Declaration, clearly underscoring the growing global consensus on combating terrorism.

India has moved from defensive restraint to proactive counter-terrorism

Concept

The 9/11 al-Qaeda attack wasn't the first major terror attack globally or against the US, but it fundamentally changed how terrorism would be fought in the decades since.

Large terror groups under leaders like Osama bin Laden or Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi are less common now; terror has morphed into smaller, autonomous entities, with lone-wolf attacks becoming the norm and drones, cyber capabilities, and AI used by both terrorists and counter-terror states.

Cross-border terror began in Kashmir in the early 1990s, but the first major attack was actually the LTTE's assassination of Rajiv Gandhi (May 1991) in Tamil Nadu.

With no clear counter-terror strategy, India was stretched by attacks like the 1993 Mumbai serial blasts (250+ killed) and 1998 Coimbatore blasts, exposing weak internal security detection/response mechanisms.

Pakistan's direct role first surfaced with the December 1999 IC-814 hijacking, forcing India to release militants including Masood Azhar for 160+ hostages. The December 2001 Parliament attack by JeM outraged India, triggering large-scale military mobilisation (Operation Parakram). With both nations nuclear-armed, the world intervened to de-escalate; the standoff ended after ~2 years without punishing Pakistan.

The 26/11 Mumbai attacks (India's "9/11 moment") also brought no military action.

After the 2014 change in central government, India resolved not to let terror go unpunished. The September 2016 Uri attack by JeM led to India's first cross-border surgical strikes (Sept 28-29, 2016) : a clear statement of intent.

Following the February 2019 Pulwama attack on a CRPF convoy, the IAF struck a JeM camp in Balakot, the first time the IAF crossed into Pakistani airspace to hit a terror target.

The April 2025 Pahalgam attack outraged the nation like never before. PM Modi, on a Saudi visit, returned and India launched Operation Sindoor (May 6-7), hitting the heart of Pakistan's terror network, within 96 hours destroying LeT/JeM leadership and headquarters and pulverising Pakistani military assets.

India has moved from a passive, reactive Kashmir policy (early 1990s) to a leading global voice against terrorism.

India unveiled PRAHAAR, its first comprehensive National Counter-Terrorism Policy and Strategy, on February 23, 2026, a national framework using coordinated "whole-of-government" and "whole-of-society" approaches.

Copper Prices Up: Fear of Trump Tariffs Amid US-China Tensions

- ECONOMY

Copper prices up: Fear of Trump tariffs amid US-China tensions

Pratyush Deep

New Delhi, September 13

COPPER PRICES have surged in recent months to hit a record high of \$14,767.5 per tonne on September 9. Three-month copper futures, which are contracts for future purchase, on the London Metal Exchange (LME) remained above the \$14,000-per-tonne mark for most of August before climbing in September.

Why copper price rise matters

The red metal is essential to the modern economy, with uses ranging from housing and manufacturing to power grids, clean energy, artificial intelligence and defence. Thus, its price is often seen as a barometer of economic health. A rise in copper prices is considered a signal of robust economic growth, while falling prices tend to raise concerns about an economic slowdown.

However, the current rally appears to have a different story.

According to industry insiders, the surge is less about expectations of stronger global economic growth and more about concerns over potential tariffs by the United States, which could come into effect from January 2027.

US-led factors

While US President Donald Trump imposed a 50% tariff on semi-finished and derivative copper imports in August last year, refined copper has so far been exempted. However, there is a proposal to impose a 15% tariff on refined copper imports from January, to be increased to 30% in 2028.

"In anticipation of US tariffs, people are selling materials from LME warehouses to warehouses of US COMEX (Commodity Exchange). As a result, there has been a shortage of copper stocks that can be traded on the LME. That is why the futures prices have gone up," an industry executive told *The Indian Express*.

This has resulted in a huge buildup of

Against trend

● Copper price is often seen as a barometer of economic health. A rise in copper prices is considered a signal of robust growth, while falling prices tend to raise concerns about an economic slowdown.

● However, the latest rise comes despite prospects of steady global economic growth clouded by trade tensions, the West Asia conflict, and uncertainty.

inventories in the US, two industry sources told *The Indian Express*. "Inventory at LME is currently at 2,65,000 tonnes, and inventory at Shanghai Futures Exchange (SHFE) is at around 63,000 tonnes. However, the inventory of US' COMEX is at around 7,00,000 tonnes," an industry source told *The Indian Express*.

Sumit Jhunjunwala, Vice President & Sector Head, Corporate Sector Ratings, ICRA Ltd, also said that copper prices have remained elevated mainly due to constrained mine supply and the ongoing geographical rebalancing of inventories. "Any major delay or lower-than-expected US tariff could reverse these inventory flows, potentially releasing accumulated stocks into global markets and exerting downward pressure on copper prices," Jhunjunwala said.

Copper in US-China trade war

Last year, too, Trump's imposition of a 50% tariff on semi-finished and derivative copper imports prompted US buyers to

stockpile the metal ahead of its implementation on August 1, heavily contributing to the surge in copper prices.

The move followed a report submitted by the US Secretary of Commerce, which claimed that copper imports threatened to impair US national security.

In 2025, the US imported \$16.2 billion worth of copper products. China accounted for 20% of these imports, followed by Mexico at 17%, the European Union at 14%, Canada at 10% and Vietnam at 8%, as per the US Congressional Research Service.

In April that year, Trump announced a 50% tariff on the full value of semi-finished copper products and a 25% tariff on the full value of copper-intensive derivative products. The latter rate was reduced to 10% where at least 95% of the copper, steel and aluminium used in the product was sourced from the US. These tariff measures are part of broader trade tensions between the US and China, with China being the world's largest consumer of copper.

Concept

Copper is a naturally occurring chemical element with the symbol Cu.

Occurrence: It is found as a free metal in nature. It also occurs in minerals like chalcocite, chalcopyrite, and bornite.

Physical Properties: It is known for its high conductivity, malleability, and corrosion resistance.

Recyclability: Copper is 100% recyclable without any loss in quality, making it an eco-friendly metal.

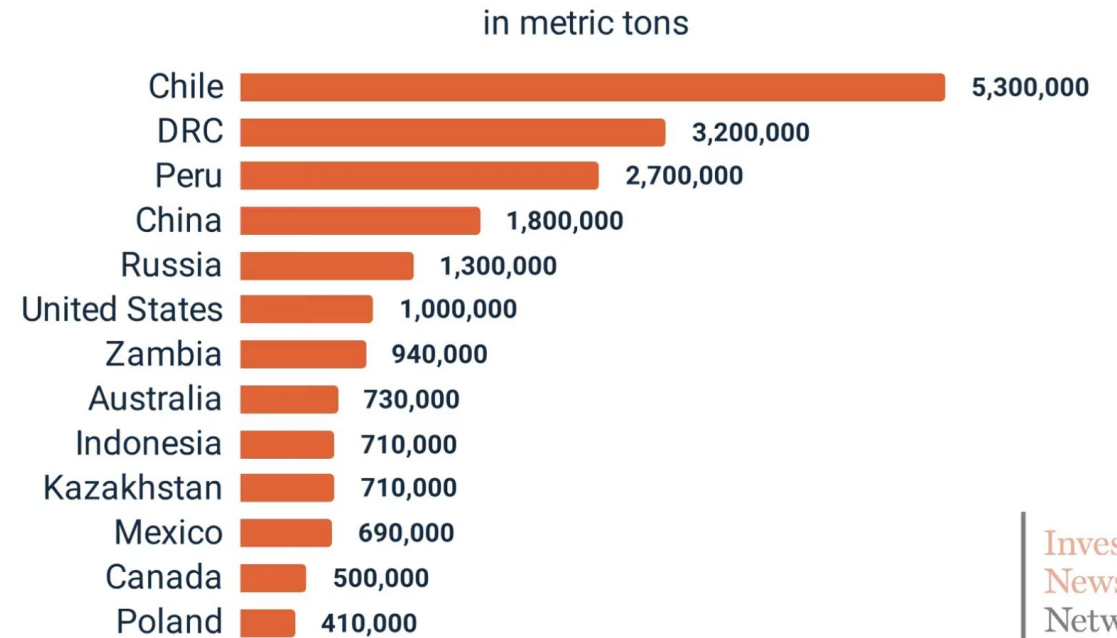
Rajasthan: Khetri and Jhunjhunu belt.

Madhya Pradesh: Malanjkhand mine, the largest open-pit copper mine in India.

Jharkhand: Singhbhum copper belt.

States : Rajasthan (50%) > Madhya Pradesh (24%)

Global Copper Production in 2025



Source: USGS

The Choice Is Between AI Applications and AI Frontiers

The choice is between AI applications and AI frontiers



SUVRAT RAJU

Countries that fall behind in developing frontier AI risk suffering the fate of those that missed the Industrial Revolution: A small business elite might prosper, but ordinary people will be disempowered

INDIA IS facing a technological crisis. Even as US and Chinese firms have released a parade of increasingly capable AI models this year, India has no competitive frontier model and no realistic prospect of producing one without significant policy shifts. The anticipated impact of AI can be separated into two categories. First, AI can diffuse through the economy by automating some routine jobs. Each industry will require specialised applications built on foundation models. India has an active start-up ecosystem devoted to building such applications, and businesses have rapidly adopted AI tools. However, AI will also have a strategic impact on research, cybersecurity and defence. AI models have been used to solve some of the most important open problems in mathematics. Anthropic's Mythos model has formidable cybersecurity capabilities; it has not been released publicly, and is available only to selected organisations.

Currently, consumers have access to other frontier models, including Chinese open-weight models. But it is unrealistic to expect this to continue indefinitely. Earlier this year, the US temporarily imposed export restrictions both on Mythos and on a version of Mythos with guardrails called Fabre. It is likely to restrict and regulate AI to "achieve global dominance". US industry leaders and academics have advised India to focus on applications rather than the frontiers — a position supported by sections of the Indian IT industry. But countries that fall behind in frontier AI risk suffering the fate of those that missed the Industrial Revolution: A small business elite might find a niche and prosper, but ordinary people will suffer disempowerment.

India can still catch up to the frontier with a focused effort. The algorithms underlying modern AI models are widely understood. The industry has exploited "scaling laws" that predict how a model's performance improves with its size and the computing power used for its training. So, while better algorithms improve efficiency, the basic formula for producing frontier models is to scale compute and data. Lack of computing power has bottlenecked sovereign Indian model development. The IndiaAI mission has a pool of 45,000 GPUs. But this is only a fraction of the capacity controlled by a single US frontier lab. The mission allocated 4,096 GPUs to Sarvam AI to train India's flagship model. This is about 50 times smaller than what is used to train frontier models. No amount of ingenuity can compensate for this resource gap. A number of data centres, with significant computing capacity, are coming up in various states. But these will primarily serve MNCs, and their location in India offers no tangible benefits. Most of the announced capital investment will be directed to electronic equipment, and the employment they create will be limited to a few construction and maintenance jobs. Large data centres have a significant environmental impact. In India, this impact will be borne disproportionately by local communities.

India could use these data centres to alleviate its compute shortage with a "compute tax". Any data centre established in India would be required to reserve, say, 25 per cent of its computing capacity for a publicly administered national compute pool. This capacity would remain physically within the data centre, but could be allocated by a central scheduler to Indian institutions. MNCs are likely to resist, but their bargaining position is weak given the growing hostility to these installations elsewhere. Such a tax would not obviate the other data-centre concerns. But together with environmental safeguards and welfare measures, it might open a narrow route to building a frontier model in India.

The writer is professor of Physics, International Centre for Theoretical Sciences, Bengaluru. Views are personal

Concept

The problem:

India is falling behind in AI. Other countries (US, China) are building powerful "frontier" AI models. India has none, and no real plan to build one.

Two kinds of AI matter:

Using AI: apps built on top of existing AI models (India is good at this, lots of startups do it)

Building AI: creating the actual advanced models from scratch (India can't do this yet)

Issues : Lack of GPUs (Graphical Processing Unit)

Way ahead : Force every data centre built in India to hand over about 25% of its computing power to a shared national pool available to Indian researchers and institutions.

Thank You,